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Rain brings joy and life to various organisms on earth. Have you noticed some changes in and around you after the rain? Could you identify the reason for the slippery nature of the terrace and green patches on the wall of our home, green colour of puddles and ponds? Why should we clean our water tanks very often? The reason is algae. Algae are simple plants that lack true roots, true stems and true leaves. Two-third of our earth's surface is covered by oceans and seas. The photosynthetic plants called algae are present here. More than half of the total primary productivity of the world depends on this plant group. Further, other aquatic organisms also depend upon them for their existence.



M.O.Parthasarathy (1886-1963)

'Father of Indian Phycology'.

He conducted research on structure, cytology, reproduction and taxonomy of Algae. He published a Monograph on Volvocales. New algal forms like *Fritschiella, Ecballocystopsis, Charasiphon* and *Cylindrocapsopsis*. were reported by him.

Algae are autotrophs, and grow in a wide range of habitats. Majority of them are aquatic, marine (*Gracilaria,* and *Sargassum*) and freshwater (*Oedogonium,* and *Ulothrix*) and also found in soils (*Fritschiella,* and *Vaucheria*). *Chlorella* lead an endozoic life in hydra and sponges whereas *Cladophora crispata* grow on the shells of molluscs. Algae are adapted to thrive in harsh environment too. *Dunaliella salina* grows in salt pans (**Halophytic alga**). Algae growing in snow are called **Cryophytic algae**. *Chlamydomonas nivalis* grow in snow covered mountains and impart red colour to the snow (**Red snow**). A few algae grow on the surface of aquatic plants and are called **epiphytic algae** (*Coleochaete,* and *Rhodymenia*). The study of algae is called **algology** or **phycology**. Some of the eminent algologists include F.E. Fritsch, F.E. Round, R.E. Lee, M.O.Parthasarathy Iyengar, M.S. Randhawa, Y. Bharadwaja, V.S. Sundaralingam and T.V.Desikachary.

2.3.1 General Characteristic features

The algae show a great diversity in size, shape and structure. A wide range of thallus organisation is found in algae. Unicellular motile (*Chlamydomonas*), unicellular non-motile (*Chlorella*), Colonial motile (*Volvox*), Colonial non motile (*Hydrodictyon*), siphonous (*Vaucheria*), unbranched filamentous (*Spirogyra*), branched filamentous (*Cladophora*), discoid (*Coleochaete*) heterotrichous (*Fritschiella*), Foliaceous (*Ulva*) to Giant Kelps (*Laminaria* and *Macrocystis*). The thallus organization in algae is given in Figure 2.3.

Algae are Eukaryotes except blue green algae. The plant body does not show differentiation into tissue systems. The cell wall of algae is made up of cellulose and hemicellulose. Siliceous walls are present in diatoms. In *Chara* the thallus is encrusted with calcium carbonate. Some algae possess algin, polysulphate esters of polysaccharides which are the